

with all the effects turned down, it looks better than *Far Cry*, and that's not bad at all. Turns out we won't have to spring for that extra card after all—and even at home, we'll get ourselves some visual joy.

Then there are the times when we just *have* to turn on all the special effects. To offset that, the strategy that's worked beautifully—more on CRTs than LCDs—is to turn down the resolution, all the way down to 640 x 480 if need be (and if the game supports it, of course). In fact, if you turn down the resolution to 512 x 384, graphics even acquire an interlaced effect—reminiscent of cutscenes in old-school games.

Recent games won't let you go below 1024 x 768, unfortunately; but why must we always talk about the latest games, anyway?



Games like *Katamari Damacy* are still a big argument in favour PS2

They're Not Going Away

Just recently, this writer completed *Max Payne 1* and *2* on his modest rig—which, incidentally, runs the game at 1280 x 1024 (probably more, if it weren't for the monitor) with all the bells and whistles—and enjoyed it thoroughly. Today's hardware lets yesterday's games look *much* better than they did back then...

If you're upgrading now and don't have the budget for a high-end gaming machine, just invest in the best your budget gets you and take a trip back in time. Buy games that wouldn't have had a prayer on your older PC and play them—it's gameplay that makes a game enjoyable, so what was good then is still good now. The cherry on the cake is that these games are even cheaper now!

As for the latest lot, they'll still be there when you're ready for your next upgrade. For less money. If you wait for hardware prices to fall before buying, who's to say you can't wait for game prices to drop, too?

And then there are some things that you shouldn't even consider buying...

The "Professional" Gamer

One of the biggest ploys that budding gamers succumb to is the "Made for professional gamers" tag on products. "Well", they think, "if the professionals use it, maybe it'll help my game too!"

It won't—specifically in the gaming mice department. If you can't strike fear in the hearts of your opponents with a run-of-the-mill mouse, forget about being able to do so with a 5000-rupee mouse and a 2000-rupee mousepad (yes, you get those). Sure, gaming mice are more precise and you can't beat on-the-fly sensitivity adjustment, but nothing makes up for solid skill. The usual victors of our *Quake III* sessions are people who have some of the most awful mice in the office.

If you must get yourself a gaming mouse, get a Logitech MX518—it'll cost you around Rs 1,300, and it's a good mouse for general Windows productivity to boot. As for the mousepad, pick up one that's preferably got a fabric finish and is a single solid colour—it'll cost around Rs 20. To hack up your own gaming mousepad, check out our June 2007 issue.

But wait...

Consoul Curry

All this while, we've been talking about PC gaming—but the best way to save money as a gamer is to shift platforms altogether. The PS2 has been a viable gaming solution for nigh on ten years, so while we've been running to upgrade our PCs every time a new game comes out, PS2 owners have been pointing at us and laughing.

From the looks of it, the Xbox 360 and the PS3 do have the potential to last another ten years—games haven't even begun to fully exploit the hardware—but we wouldn't be surprised at a new console in five years, for marketing reasons if nothing else. Even so, you'll be paying only once in these five years, and the cost of a next-gen (or current-gen, now that they've been around a while) console is less than what you'd pay for a killer PC (not counting the cost of an HDTV, though). The games are a bit expensive, but the wait-for-prices-to-drop approach will work here too.

Even the PS2 still has plenty of steam, and if you're new to the platform, this is the best time to buy. You can get your hands on it for as little as Rs 7,000, and titles are finally going below the Rs 1,000 mark too. You'll have a huge collection of legendary games—the *God Of War* duo, the *Burnout* titles, and many more—to keep you busy for a long time, and new releases are lined up till July this year at the very least.

If you're a first-person shooter (FPS) or real-time strategy (RTS) fan, though, don't go the console way even in a moment of weakness—such games are best enjoyed with a keyboard and mouse.

Cheat Code

If all else fails—if you've already spent your life doing the same things we're telling you to do here and can't take it anymore, get those books out and brush up on your grammar. Then apply for a job here at *Digit* and start reviewing the latest games as soon as (and sometimes before) they release—that's what we did, anyway. □

nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com